

Angst of the OUTCASTE

An anti-Brahminical polemicist argues why the days of Hinduism are numbered

By Mark Tully



POST-HINDU
INDIA

by KANCHAI LAIAH

Sage

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This is a startling book, revealing the extent of the anger and hurt of the author, a well-known OBC academic and social-activist. It's a polemic on what his experiences as an OBC as well as his academic research on Dalit and tribal communities have led him to see as a centuries-old Brahmin conspiracy. The conspiracy to subjugate the Dalits, the tribals and the Shudras too. Kancha Ilaiah equates Hinduism with Brahminism. He says, "For any external observer Hinduism is nothing but an institutionalized image of the Brahmin self; although some people say it is a religion that encompasses all the castes."

Ilaiah attacks what he considers to be Hinduism for imposing an order on society which is neither egalitarian nor pluralist. The caste system is responsible for this imposition, and it is still in place, he says, because democracy hasn't affected the domination of the upper castes. They are accused of being "spiritual fascists", and "intellectual goondas". Ilaiah maintains that the spiritual fascism was so constructed by Brahmins that those who were its victims could not comprehend its essence. In other words, a confidence trick has been played on them.

He calls the Dalits, tribals and the Shudras Dalit-Bahujans and sees them as the productive sections of society while regarding the upper castes as mere parasites. If they had not fostered the caste system and prevented intermarriage, Ilaiah believes there would have been an interchange of the technology practiced by different castes in their professions and India would have become a scientific society. He quotes as an example of the Dalit's technology of tanning animal skins and manufacturing shoes and other leather products. Brahminism is seen by him as anti-scientific, and disinterested even in such basic subjects as agriculture. He accuses it of seeing "knowledge as ignorance, and ignorance as knowledge", and doesn't credit it with a single scientific discovery. In fact he believes the position is even worse than that. The Brahmins are accused of stealing the discoveries of the Dalit-Bahujans. Ilaiah maintains that zero was discovered by cattle



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herders and many Ayurvedic medicines by Shudras, Dalits or tribals, but Brahmins have claimed them as their own.

Ilaiah does not merely concentrate on the economic and other material problems created by the caste system. He believes it is essential for the Dalits, tribals and Shudras to acquire a spirituality which is egalitarian and pluralist. He says, "The first major agenda for post-Hindu India is to build a spiritual democratic basis... A religious structure that guarantees their right to spiritual equality." He compares Hinduism with Christianity, Islam and Buddhism, which he sees as egalitarian and pluralist religions, and lays great emphasis on Ambedkar's rejection of Hinduism and adoption